

It was a quiet day. The sky was clear, and the sun was just above the hills. A soft wind passed through the grass, but nothing else moved. There were no cars, no voices, no hums or beeps. Just the sound of leaves and the hush of the air. Tom sat alone on a flat rock near the field. He had been there for some time, looking ahead, not saying a word.

Beside him was a small brown bag. Inside was a folded map and a single piece of bread. He took the map out and spread it on his lap. It showed only a few things: a tree, a lake, and a mark in red. The mark was near the edge of the map, close to where the sky met the field. Tom looked up, then stood. He brushed dust from his pants and stepped off the rock.

The grass was dry under his feet, and the earth felt soft. He walked with calm steps, one at a time, without rush. A bird passed overhead but did not call out. The path ahead curved toward a line of trees. Some trees were tall, but one stood out—it had no leaves, no green, just dry bark and a long crack down the middle. Tom walked straight toward it.

When he reached the tree, he paused. At its base sat a small box, square and black, covered in dust. He knelt down and touched it. The box was cold. He opened it slowly. Inside was a bell, small and round, red with a hint of gold. It did not ring. He held it in his palm. It felt light, almost too light. He gave it a gentle shake. Still, no sound.

Then the wind stopped. The sky dimmed, just slightly. Tom stood still. The air felt close, like it had paused to see what would happen next. He looked around. Nothing changed. So he put the bell back in the box, closed it, and stepped away.

He pulled out the map once more. The red mark was gone. In its place was a small gold star, farther from where he stood. It pointed toward the lake. So Tom walked again. This time, the way felt longer. The ground rose and fell in slow waves. He passed a small hill, then a patch of wild grass, and then he saw it—the lake.

It was wide and flat, like a sheet of glass. No waves moved. No ripples reached the edge. A single duck sat still at the far side. Tom found a log that stretched across part of the water. It looked weak, but he stepped on it with care. It shifted under him, but held. Slowly, he crossed.

On the other side, the grass was green and wet. The sun was now lower, and the sky had turned pale gold. Under a short tree sat another box—no bell this time. Just a soft bag, tied at the top. Tom opened it. Inside was a note. The note read, “Wait here.”

So he did. He sat beneath the tree and placed the note in his lap. He waited in silence. The light changed. The sky became pink. The stars began to blink on, one by one. He looked at each, watching their dim light pulse like breath.

After some time, a man came down the path. He wore plain clothes and held nothing in his hands. He did not speak. He came close, nodded once, and sat beside Tom. They sat together without words. The wind picked up again, just slightly. The lake shimmered.

The man stood after a while and held out his hand. Tom stood too, and they shook hands—firm but kind. The man smiled. Then he turned and walked back the way he came. Tom watched him until he was gone.

Tom sat back down, this time not under the tree but closer to the edge of the lake. He looked across the water, then up at the sky. One star blinked brighter than the rest. It blinked red. Tom took out the map again. Now it was blank. The star was gone. The path was gone. Just white space.

He folded the map, placed it in the bag, and stood up. The day was nearly done. The last light touched the top of the hills. He looked once more at the lake, the tree, and the sky. Then he smiled, not big, just a small smile to himself.

It had been a quiet day. And he liked it that way.